

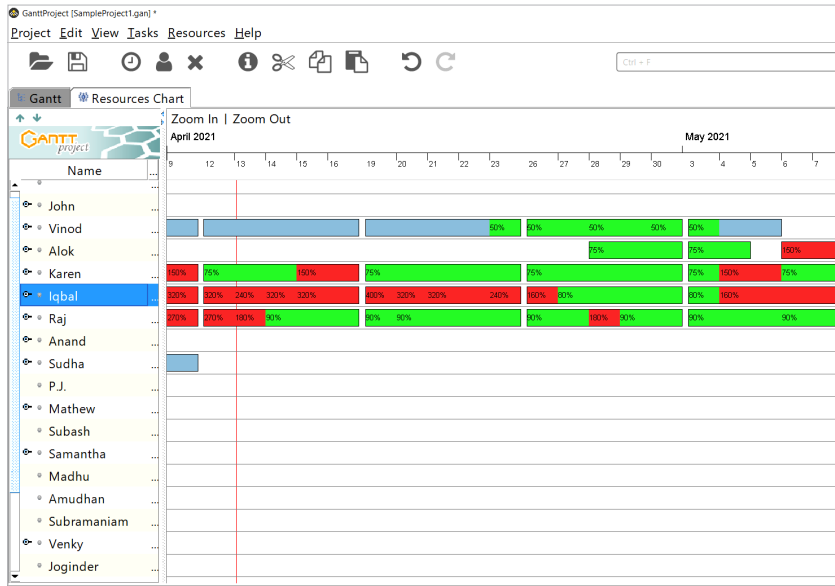


Figure 3: GanttProject 3.0 resource view

GanttProject: The new kid on the block

It is always a good practice to make a backup copy of the project file before making any major changes. In addition, GanttProject provides a *Recover* menu item under the *Help* menu. Files that are used for ‘undo’ sit in your system temporary folder (e.g., in Linux it is */tmp*). *Recover* uses these files to try to put you back to a recent stable status.

GanttProject provides import and export wizards for MSProject, spreadsheets and other file types. When importing MS Project files, it is recommended that you set default dependency hardness to ‘Rubber’ in the Gantt chart settings before you import a project. Also, it will help if you choose to overwrite your calendar in the import wizard, with the calendar in the import file. After import, it will show a list of warnings if the timeline of any of the tasks changes.

Though it is not open source, the GanttMan Android app has a free version that is able to open GanttProject .gan files. You may be able to use this to view GanttProject files on a smartphone and perhaps do some limited editing.

GanttProject also has a discussion forum which requires you to register.

However, you should try and read the FAQ and search the forum first. If you are not able to find the answer, then you can post the questions there. There are also Web and video tutorials posted by other users.

Don't expect these tools to work seamlessly with MS Project files

Though these two tools have the ability to open or import MS Project files, don't expect this to be a seamless process. Because of minor differences in the settings and approach, when you import an MS Project file, there could be some changes in the schedule. After the import, examine the source and target files carefully, and make the necessary adjustments. You can also save or export to the MS Project .xml format.

Features missing in these tools

Many experienced project managers do not like to use tools for doing automatic resource levelling. They

prefer to manually resolve resource overallocation. Depending on the nature of the task, they can assign a task to another resource, split it, schedule it at different times or even authorise overtime. However, there are others who prefer to let the tool resolve this. If you belong to this category, then you are out of luck because these open source tools cannot do automatic resource levelling. They do not support recurring tasks either.

Also, you cannot make or list schedules in hours — only in days. However, ProjectLibre can split durations into fractions of a day, such as 0.125, 1.5 or 2.25 days. Can these tools handle master projects and sub-projects? The short answer is ‘no’. But the long answer is, ‘there is a workaround’. Let us say you want to set up a master project with three sub-projects. Instead, you can create a single project with three high level tasks representing the three sub-projects, and all the tasks within these sub-projects can be indented as next level tasks. This also solves the problem of managing a single resource pool for multiple projects.

Just the basics with no bells and whistles

As you can see, these tools take you to the next level of project management capability from mere spreadsheets. At the same time, they are not cluttered with tons of fancy features, which are rarely needed but can distract you when all you are trying to do is get the basics right. You can stay on the operating system of your choice — whether Linux, Windows or Mac. Between user created Web and video tutorials, as well as FAQs and forums, rest assured you won't get stuck. **END** 🐧

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